This is the authors' version of the following article: Lee, H., & Lee, C. (2009). A study on military in *Utopia*. *Korean Journal of Military Arts and Science*, *65*(2), 135–148. The version of record is available at https://doi.org/10.31066/kjmas.2009.65.2.006. This version differs from the published article in layout and pagination; please cite the published version.

A Study on Military in *Utopia*

『유토피아』의 휴머니즘과 그 속에서의 군대에 관한 연구

이 한 솔 (Hansol Lee)
육군사관학교 영어과
이 창 원 (Changwon Lee)
육군사관학교 영어과

ABSTRACT

This paper aims to analyze *Utopia* written by Sir Thomas More where the writer attempts to construct possible institutions to reform the society through his humanistic ideas. In process of this, More carefully investigates the concept of the military where he considers the military as an indispensable base for the formation of a nation. Being mindful of applicability, More constructs the ideals based on reality and never cease to apply theses ideals upon reality. Although More admits Utopia, the ideally described world, possess certain limits and defects, he continuously examines these ideals within his deeply rooted idea of a nation-state. Interestingly, whether in the ideal or real world, there exists the concept of one's own military. That is to say, the formation of a military is not an option but a prerequisite for both ideal and real society. At the point where the nation-state was being formed, this humanistic contemplation for the military shows inevitable discrepancies between ideal and reality.

Key words: Thomas More, Utopia, Nation-state, Renaissance Humanism, Military

주제어: 토마스 모어, 유토피아, 국민 국가, 르네상스 휴머니즘, 군대

I

The Renaissance, meaning "rebirth," implies the cultural dynamism based on advanced civil representation from Aristotelian and Scholastic philosophies (Nauert 3). It was developed in the medieval civilization, and its trail of origin can always be found: for example, the philosophy was rooted in many '-isms such as Platonism where it was believed that the human spirit lies between bodily and purely transcendental worlds, and in Stoicism, which regards the universe as a sort of community for both God and human beings. In the late fifteenth century, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola said that after God had created all creatures and chain of being,

He created man last (Nauert 75). Mirandola thereby claimed that only man could choose one's position in the chain of being and have the freedom to define one's own characteristics (Nauert 76).

Considering the distinct humanism in the Renaissance era, human was a superior being not because he/she was the one who could be saved by God but because human was a natural being that possessed both spirit and physical body. In other words, depending upon one's choice, man could become either a spiritual being or a mere sensual animal. In this context, it would be fair to say that the Reformation that arose in the early fifteenth century was relevant to the abovementioned humanism. In the contemporary era, Vatican's efforts to continue building new churches and propagating their God dramatically increased the sales of indulgence, the ticket to heaven, which were thought to have redeemed one's sins; Martin Luther confronted this indulgence sales with his *95 Theses* against corrupt churches and kindled a flame on the outbreak of the Reformation. The reason that someone like Luther was able to effectuate his ideas, and the denomination like Protestantism proclaiming denial of God-Pope-King hierarchy could interest people was the distinct viewpoint on the world quite different from the medieval historical consciousness; especially in such a society where the power was centered around the Pope and the absolute Catholic order of rank existed. According to Jacob Burckhardt, a nineteenth century Swedish historian, this type of human-oriented philosophy not only toppled the feudal economy and eliminated the power of corrupt Christian members, but also built a base for the nation-state (Nauert 2). That is to say, the Renaissance humanism favored human-oriented view of the world rather than God-oriented outlook, immanence of humanism than Catholic transcendentalism, and secular cultures than metaphysical religions. In fact, the medieval viewpoint of the world that everything is decided under the Providence of God, was changed to that of the Renaissance, which is to say, the rules of society can be changed by human beings.

The status of the Pope, used to be the central power of authority, was no longer able to maintain its role, and as a result there was a relative reinforcement in the power of the kings in the European region. There were attempts from kings not only to retrieve the power and authority from the Pope but also to strengthen their power as monarchs of their nations. At the same time, each state, with its king as the center, started to build the basis for becoming a nation-state. Moreover, the fact that the Latin Bible was translated into various vernaculars expanded the use of their own languages, leading the people of each country to reinforce their national identities. The kings then focused on expanding the territories they ruled and looked for means and ways to protect their own countries. Rather than employing tenants for battle, they searched for mercenaries with a specialty for fighting and also proceeded in producing regular-armies for further security (Hunt 32).

Analyzing *Utopia* written by Sir Thomas More, at this point, would be a meaningful work. In fact, this paper aims to delve into the logics of humanistic philosophy on how shaping a military can lead to build a foundation for a nation-state. In the early sixteenth century, the time when More wrote the book, England was moving into the Modern Ages from the Middle Ages and experiencing huge changes of economical system from feudalism to capitalism. Through More's work, rather than simply criticizing the complicated and chaotic reality, he describes an ideal community or society where he could imagine a world which can be changed by the will of human beings. In this sense, a figure like Hythlodaeus can be seen as one of the representatives of the Renaissance man, who believes such social phenomenon as the grim realities of life throughout the society was caused not by the Providence of God but by certain defects in the social and political system. He struggles to find the causes and fix these problems. *Utopia*, therefore, is not a simple science fiction, but is a piece of Renaissance literature that represents the contemporary historical views and cultures.

II

Thomas More's *Utopia* is divided into two parts. The first part consists of the conversation among Thomas More, the British ambassador to Antwerp, Peter Giles, one of the famous Dutch humanists, and Hythlodaeus who had just been to a trip to a new world called Utopia. The second part is composed of Hythlodaeus's descriptions and interpretation of the communal society in Utopia based on his experience and memory. As this work is heavily supported by these monologues of Hythlodaeus, the early criticism regards the main focus of work as Hythlodaeus's interpretations and consciousness about Utopia. For instance, Karl Kautsky noted the literature as a presentation of Marxian-type communistic model, and R. W. Chambers analyzed it as a criticism against the emerging democracy requesting a representation of the medieval orders based on Christianity (Kautsky 125-131).

Harry Berger, however, read the literature with more emphasis on Thomas More the narrator, who argued against these new ideas of Hythlodaeus (63-74).[1] In fact, Utopia as illustrated in *Utopia*, seems to be a fantasy of an unusual world, and at the same time, an innuendo of actuality of the epoch; it may be seen as an ideal alternative to the current world, or a fancy escape from reality. The importance of the work, however, is that it is based on actual history containing contemporary culture and historical view. In other words, reading *Utopia* is thinking about the conversation among Hythlodaeus, Giles, and More the narrator, and the work is not about judging which particular ideology is right or wrong but about the proposal of both idealism and realism and the balance between those supported by the ability of the human being in a highly politically, economically, and religiously confusing world. That is to say, by

speaking through More the narrator and Hythlodaeus, the author shows his insights into the problems throughout the society. In addition, he reveals the essence in the philosophy of Renaissance humanism by showing his effort and anguish to find solutions to these problems.

In *Utopia*, the peasants whose lives are victimized by the social system stand in the middle of objects where Thomas More considers changes and reforms are necessary. Looking upon the Enclosure movement, the switching of farmland to pasture for wool production rather than that of grain, he pays attention to the effects that brought peasants to give up farming, devastation to farms, and increase in poverty. He then describes the sheep as "man-eaters" (46), and illustrates peasants as beings which are eaten by them.

> Sheeps, . . . these placid creatures, which used to require so little food, have now apparently developed a raging appetite, and turned into man-eaters. Fields, houses, towns, everything goes down their throats. To put it more plainly, in those parts of the kingdom where the finest, and so the most expensive wool is produced, the nobles and gentlemen, not to mention several saintly abbots, have grown dissatisfied with the income that their predecessors got out of their estates. They're no longer content to lead lazy, comfortable lives, which do no good to society—they must actively do it harm, by enclosing all the land they can for pasture, and leaving none for cultivation. They're even tearing down houses and demolishing whole towns—except, of course, for the churches, which they preserve for use as sheepfolds. As though they didn't waste enough of your soil already on their coverts and game-preserves, these kind souls have started destroying all traces of human habitation, and turning every scrap of farmland into a wilderness. (46-7)

The descriptions of peasants are slightly exaggerated, but it is sufficient to show a cross-section of the society's transitional period from agricultural to industrial society. Thomas More especially points out that even though the peasants lost their homes and jobs, there was nothing churches could do to help them. He noticed that what harmed peasants was not the Providence of God but instead it was the social system that valued sheep above people. In other words, it was the system that laid more weight on money and the desire of those who possess those.

More, therefore, suggests through the voice of Hythlodaeus that the essence of Utopia should be the system that does not allow a private property. He saw it as the primary source of social evils, and stressed that the only solution to root out these ills was to abolish money or capitalism.

> I'm quite convinced that you'll never get a fair distribution of goods, or a satisfactory organization of human life, until you abolish private property altogether. So long as it exists, the vast majority of the human race, and the vastly superior part of it, will inevitably go on

> labouring under a burden of poverty, hardship, and worry. I don't say that the burden can't be reduced, but you'll never take it right off their shoulders, . . . there's no hope of a cure, so long as private property continues. (66)

The abuse in a monetary society where money is used to exploit peasants to fulfill one's desire, then is used to fill up his pride to hold a more prominent position than others, and using power and authority acquired from them to justify his wrongdoing, begins with the private ownership system. To put it concretely, starting from the unfair distribution of commodities, then adding up sloth, greed, and pride of human being, leaves no room for the social equality to exist. For instance, in the society like Utopia described by Hythlodaeus where complete and perfect equality does exist, such an incident where humans are satirically eaten by sheep certainly would not happen.

However, it should be noticed that Utopia is not an autobiography or a travel writing of Hythlodaeus. Although Thomas More criticized the social problems at the time and suggested the alternative proposals, he at the same time criticized these proposals by introducing another main figure, Thomas More the narrator. That is the criticism against the concept of communism in Utopia—that everything is equal for everyone.

> I disagree. I don't believe you'd ever have a reasonable standard of living under a communist system. There'd always tend to be shortages, because nobody would work hard enough. In the absence of a profit motive, everyone would become lazy, and rely on everyone else to do the work for him. Then, when things really got short, the inevitable result would be a series of murders and riots, since nobody would have any legal method of protecting the products of his own labour—especially as there wouldn't be any respect for authority, or I don't see how there could be, in a classless society. (67)

As Harry Berger and R. W. Chambers insist, More the narrator, disagrees with the proposed idealism by Hythlodaeus and points out the discrepancy between the ideal and reality. As witnessed in the Soviet Union and Communist Chinese, and as it is the current case of North Korea, he sharply indicates the critical defect of communism which includes the lack of the motivation caused by the deficiency of individual benefits, and the consequent decline in productivity of labor throughout the society as each individual attempts to rely on the efforts of others. More, however, does not support or insist one particular economic system in this work. Instead, he simply suggests that it is possible for men to enter and change the society that they themselves created. That is why it is not necessary to support either More the narrator or Hythlodaeus or attempt to derive a conclusion from their debate. Rather, the focus should be on the More's struggles to deduce the possibility of contributable reorganizations of the commonwealth.

III

In spite of Thomas More's ceaseless attempts to deduce new ideas by examining reality, applying these new ideas on the real society finally meets cul-de-sac. In fact, what is spotted first in the following conclusion of the debate between Hythlodaeus and More the narrator is despondency.

> So there you have a group of people who are deeply prejudiced against everyone else's ideas, or at any rate prefer their own. Suppose, in such company, you suggest a policy that you've seen adopted elsewhere, or for which you can quote a historical precedent, what will happen? They'll behave as though their professional reputations were at stake, and they'd look fools for the rest of their lives as if they couldn't raise some objection to you proposal. Failing all else, their last resort will be: 'This was good enough for our ancestors, and who are we to question their wisdom?' Then they'll settle back in their chairs, with an air of having said the last word on the subjection—as if it would be a major disaster for anyone to be caught being wiser than his ancestors! (42-3)

> I[Thomas More] certainly hope we shall, some day. In the meantime I cannot agree with everything that he said, for all his undoubted learning and experience. But I freely admit that there are many features of the Utopian Republic which I should like—though I hardly expect—to see adopted in Europe. (132)

This humanist approach to eliminate social evils, after all, fails at the practical level of applying it to reality. At that time, to project one's ideas into society he must carry out his ideas in the confusing world where his efforts becomes a mere armchair theory, and must persuade the man who possesses the power and authority of commonwealth: the king. Moreover, one may lose his valuable life in case of disagreement even without an attempt of persuasion.

The focus, however, should not be on the limitation of More for not being able to derive conclusions but on the consistent efforts he made within his limitations, and these limitations should be valued as fruitful work that contains humanistic philosophy. The efforts of humanists in Utopia and their contemplation to correct the society through the power of man by finding out the ideal social system in this contemplation, are the key elements that make these humanists Renaissance men. More to this, they approach the social problems not through religious or idealistic but realistic and concrete way. This is the manifest evidence that the humanism lies in belief that a social system and phenomenon can be reformed by human beings themselves. Particularly, the reasons for Hythlodaeus not being able to adopt his experienced ideal social system to his country and More the narrator remaining pessimistic to

the assertions proposed by Hythlodaeus are due to the boundaries of “nation.” This limitation, however, should be seen as the ground that leads to the political conception formed at that time; in other words, the conception of the nation-state.

Interestingly, the Utopia that Hythlodaeus illustrates has a geographic advantage of protecting its commonwealth from invasions by others. In other words, there exists an established conception of national security and stability that a nation must possess to allow such social reformations like abolition of money and private property to take place. At the same time, this shows the inevitable limitations and conflict against the reality when the humanists in the literature respectively attempt to apply their ideal concepts to the real society and put them on the table for discussion. What is noticed then is that the meaning of “nation” and the subsequent meaning of “military” for its protection are deeply rooted in Thomas More’s conception. The Utopia that he illustrates through Hythlodaeus forms an ideal nation that is basically freed from the social evils such as oppression of authority or wars. Therefore, he subsequently emphasizes the need for the avoidance of wars in order to pursue the security and safety for a nation.

In this sense, the military Thomas More suggests in *Utopia* is closer to that of a nation-state where the army is supported by loyalty from its own people and society, and this military is distinct from the armies of absolute monarchs whose base is limited to representation of king’s own will and interest. In fact, considering that humans started using languages for communication since five hundred thousand years ago and conflicts between groups which can be seen as war also started around the same time, it can be noticed that military emerged around the same time as the birth of the human being, and it is an ironic means of self-protection that protects human while harming others. However, at the point when nation-states start to emerge, the contemplation of the formation and utilization of the military is somewhat significant. That is to say, a military does not only exist to protect its citizens from a different level of social evil such as wars and oppression, but the existence of military is also acknowledged as the most critical basis for a nation. This is a very similar logic proposed by Machiavelli, the logic that the key foundations of a nation are “good laws” and “good arms”, and only the military of its own country can become a good army (Machiavelli 35). Although Utopians can effectively utilize mercenaries and auxiliary troops to participate in wars, it is believed that the ultimate means of maintaining the existence of the nation is one’s own military.[2]

Likewise, Utopia holds its own military and has necessary geographical advantage for national defense. These subsequently promote the domestic peace and order by disallowing invasion by foreign countries. To protect the stability of commonwealth, it turns out to be evident that Utopia is similar to a nation-state where it is justified to operate armed forces against other

states as a means of self-defense.[3] This externalization of violence, inevitably leads Utopians to have unbalanced viewpoints toward people of its own nation and that of others respectively (Giddens 267). As a result, the ground for More's belief, that any other form of forces except one's own military is useless, begins with the nationality: no one is adequate for national defense, but only Utopians themselves.

Particularly, Thomas More does not let the problems of money go away—the critical reason for before-mentioned social evils. In other words, the logic that conflicts between nations also arise from the greed and avarice of human beings applies to all human beings except Utopians, whose social system is idealized and consequently differentiated from that of others. Mercenaries, especially, do not have contracts based on fixed period of time, but instead they have a tendency to stand on any side in a war depending on amount of money each side pays. This sometimes causes incidents where the same tribes aim their weapons on each other. Utopians, accordingly, disparage the mercenaries only as a necessary tool used for wars.

> So most of their fighting is done by mercenaries. They recruit them from all over the world, but especially from a place called Venalia, which is about five hundred miles to the east of Utopia. . . . They fight for their employers with great loyalty and zeal, but won't guarantee how long they'll continue to do so. They join you on the understanding that they'll join your enemy tomorrow, if he'll pay them better, and be back with you the day after that, if you'll give them a little bit more. . . . For the Utopians don't care how many Venalians they send to their deaths. They say, if only they could wipe the filthy scum off the face of the earth completely, they'd be doing the human race a very good turn. (112-3)

Ironically, though Utopians attempt to protect their nation and citizens by employing a number of methods, their attitude towards mercenaries makes them close to realistic Machiavellians rather than warm-hearted humanists.

Like mercenaries, auxiliaries are not considered as intimate objects by Utopians. Although they are not objects that are controlled by money, Utopians only employ them when necessary since they do not lie under Utopian social system. Ultimately, Utopians only see them as one of useful tools to achieve their objectives. In case of a war, of course, the entire command and control lies under Utopians. In particular, More's emphasis on one's own military indicates the difficult balance between ideals and reality that is the blind spot of two bilaterally paradoxical elements, the nationalism for the nation's people and humanism for the human beings. This is the identity of the "nation" that More supposes. Utopians, therefore, look for any effective means to achieve victory even it involves an assassination of the monarch of the enemy nation. Moreover, in the case where a war takes place on their own soil, they show precaution by not bringing in any outside forces or mercenaries into their own land.

> If any king goes to war with them and prepares to invade their territory, they send off a large force to intercept him before he reaches the frontier—for they never fight on their own soil if they can help it, and in no circumstances will they allow allied troops to set foot on the island itself. (117)

The concept of Utopia, accordingly, resembles an autonomous state, protected from political and geographical foreign attacks, and is based on the idea of nation's people distinct from others. Thomas More's assumption of national security, as well as the inclination to rescue the people from social evils through national social institutions is amply humanistic. At the same time, however, he distances himself from enemies with potential threats to its national people and, hence, shows contrary attitudes to other peoples including mercenaries or auxiliaries. In other words, while building ideal institutions and minimizing the needs for regulating the people, More assumes the indispensability of military force. This illuminates us into understanding the features of the people that More creates, to appreciate that one's own military is the fundamental basis for the very existence of a nation, and together to identify the areas of rupture and contradiction that the Renaissance humanists face between reality and ideals. In sum, the military that More identifies constitutes an indispensable part of a variety of social institutions that aim to regulate human desire and insecurity. It is the basis of the creation of ideals upon reality, and yet also the limitation in applying ideals upon reality.

IV

In Utopia, Thomas More constructs the ideals through reality, and never ceases to apply the ideals upon reality. Utopia is where all constituents are equally treated by social institutions, based on effective and advantageous geographical locations. None is perfect, however. Regulating human desire and individuality, exhibiting separate standards of humanism to other peoples, or affirming slavery and suicide, all imply inhuman, totalitarian, and imperial features of More's Utopia. At the same time, on the contrary, it must be remembered that no one in the book show unconditional support for Utopia's ideal institutions. Even Hythlodaeus does not confine himself to political areas, resigning himself to reality within which he cannot change a nation himself. Together with the practical limitations of Utopia that More the narrator points out, they indicate the contemplation for more dynamic humanism rather than a failure of realizing the ideals. An interesting fact is that whether in the ideal or real world, it is made clear that the formation of the military must come first in order for a state to exist.

While dreaming the ideal world based on reality, More visualizes a state based on the assumption of minimized invasion and intervention from other states. Also, by comparing mercenaries and auxiliaries, the need for one's own military was reiterated for a nation's autonomy and peace. At the point where the nation-state was being formed, the military was

an indispensable factor in a state that More was constructing in Utopia. As a humanist to its own people, inhuman attitude to other people including foreign military forces are, without question, contradictory, but this may also serve as a representative example of friction between ideals and reality. In other words, a genuine Utopia is unachievable without a strong national force responsible for national security. When national security becomes perilous, More's thought would become more acutely relevant.

<REFERENCES>

Berger, Harry. "The Renaissance Imagination: Second World and Green World." *The Centennial Review* 9 (Winter 1965): 63-74.

Chambers, R. W. *Thomas More.* New York: Ann Arbor Paperback, 1958.

Davis, J. C. *Utopia & The Ideal Society: A Study of English Utopian Writing 1516-1700.* Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 1981.

Eliav-Feldon, Miriam. *Realistic Utopias*. Oxford: Oxford UP, 1982.

Giddens, Anthony. *The Nation-State and Violence*. Berkerly: U of California P, 1985.

Hunt, Jocelyn. *The Renaissance.* New York: Routledge, 1999.

Kautsky, Karl. *Thomas More and His Utopia.* Trans. H. J. Stennig. London: Russell & Russell, 1959.

Kraye, Jill. *The Cambridge Companion to Renaissance Humanism*. Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2004.

Levitas, Ruth. *The Concept of Utopia*. New York: Philip Allan, 1990.

Machiavelli, Niccolo. *The Prince*. Ed. Robert M. Adams. New York: Norton, 1977.

More, Thomas. *Utopia*. Trans. Paul Turner. New York: Penguin Books, 1965.

Nauert, Charles G. *Humanism and the Culture of Renaissance Europe*. Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2006.

Surtz, S. J. Edward. *The Praise of Pleasure*. Cambridge: Harvard UP, 1957.

---

1. There are two Thomas More in this work: one is the author and the other is one of the characters in the work, the narrator. In this paper, I will designate the narrator Thomas More as More the narrator.↩

2. Utopians are ready at any time to form an army for self-defence against any threats of national security as they have received regular military training: ". . . both sexes are given military training at regular intervals, so that they won't be incapable of fighting if they ever have to do it. But they hardly ever go to war, except in self-defense, to repel invaders from friendly territory, or to liberate the victims of dictatorship—which they feel sorry for them" (109).↩

3. According to the theory of Anthony Giddens, a success of “internal pacification” and monopolizing the military power of commonwealth certainly clarify the shape of a nation-state (267).↩